



Ram in the shape of a boar's head
The ships's ram *(rostrum)* was very important in Roman iconography. The beaks of Carthaginian ships captured at Mylae in 260 BCE were used to decorate the raised platform used by speakers in the Roman forum, hence the word "rostrum" meaning a speaker's podium.

WEAPONS ON BOARD

In their war against Carthage the Romans introduced the spiked corvus (see p44) as an aid to grappling and boarding. Later the extraordinary arpax was invented, a catapult used to propel grappling tackle onto an enemy ship. Most of the Romans' on-board military technology, however, was identical to that used on land. Shipborne artillery consisted of catapults and ballistas, mostly firing darts and stones as anti-personnel munitions, although they could be used to propel heavier rocks to bombard city walls during the siege of a port. Roman success at sea cannot be put down to technological superiority. Rather it was a triumph of willpower and organization. When Rome lost an entire fleet to shipwreck during the Punic Wars, it simply built and manned another to replace it. Pompey's suppression of piracy was achieved by the systematic application of ruthless force, clearing the Mediterranean area by area, leaving no hiding place for the pirates.

Rome's battles against Carthage were fought on a vast scale. In terms of the sheer numbers of men involved—probably more than 300,000—the battle of Ecnomus ranks as one of the largest naval encounters ever. By the 1st century BCE, however, the only major battles were between Roman forces engaged in civil wars. Sea power proved decisive at Actium in 31 BCE, the battle that enabled Octavian to become sole ruler of the Roman world as the Emperor Augustus.

DOMINANCE AT SEA

Since the Roman world encompassed the entire coastline of the Mediterranean, Augustus and his successors faced no major enemies at sea. But they still had need of a navy. Ships provided military supply and transport, as in the invasion of Britain in 43 CE. They also gave river support for the long military campaigns waged in Germany and Dacia. In the Mediterranean they pursued pirates and protected merchant shipping. Some 10,000 men were stationed at a great naval base on the bay of Naples, with another fleet in the Adriatic based at Ravenna, and provincial squadrons elsewhere—for example, in the Black Sea and at Alexandria. Without major enemies the Romans were able to rely for the most part on smaller galleys—triremes and liburnians. The navy was manned by volunteers signed up for 26 years' service, many recruited from among the Phoenicians, Greeks, and Egyptians with their long habit of seafaring.



A riverine navy
This scene, part of the frieze on Trajan's column in Rome, shows Roman ships on the Danube. In the first two centuries CE the Danube and Rhine formed the Roman Empire's eastern border and were patrolled by squadrons of warships.

DECLINE AND FALL

The navy participated in the general decline of the Roman Empire from the 3rd century CE. Shipborne Germanic Goths rampaged through the Aegean and British rebels challenged Roman shipping in northern seas. Meanwhile, widespread piracy revived in the Mediterranean as a weakening Roman navy lost its grip.

The 5th century brought a general collapse of Roman authority in the west. Another Germanic tribe, the Vandals, took to the sea and controlled the western Mediterranean from Carthage and other naval bases in North Africa. In 455 the Vanadal king, Geiseric sailed his fleet across to Italy and sacked the city of Rome itself. The Roman navy's inheritance was to survive, however, in the eastern half of the empire. The Byzantine Empire, centered on Constantinople, would rely on a powerful navy to uphold Rome's imperial tradition.